Office of Research Assurance

Human Subject Research Protections Standard Operating Procedures (SOP)

SOP- 450: Study Closure

Number	Effective Date	Version Number	Previous Version
450	18-Aug-2025	v.2.1	v.2

Purpose

HRP-450 establishes the process for closure of NASA IRB approved protocols.

Closure is initiated by the Principal Investigator (PI) but can be initiated and managed by the NASA IRB for approved protocols that have expired (or lapsed) or when requested by the PI.

This policy applies to all human subjects research approved by the NASA IRB.

Policy

1. All IRB approved research protocols require a study closure when research activities with human subjects are completed. Research activities include, but are not limited to:
    a. Participant enrollment
    b. Recruitment
    c. Informed consent
    d. Data collection
    e. Analysis of identifiable data
    f. Storage of identifiable data other than data archived with LSDA/LSAH
    g. Sharing of identifiable data
2. If any of the above are continuing, NASA IRB approval must be maintained and a continuing review is required, where appropriate.
3. Studies that were never initiated or discontinued prior to completion may be closed.
4. Maintaining NASA IRB Oversight:
    a. NASA IRB approval for greater than minimal risk studies expires annually, or sooner as determined by the IRB.
    b. Expedited and exempt research generally does not require continuing review. However, there may be circumstances in which the IRB determines continuing review is necessary.
5. PIs are responsible for retaining study records including signed consent forms, for three years after study closure. Signed consent forms must be kept securely and separate from the data in a manner that allows reasonable access for copying or examination in the event of an audit, inspection, etc.
6. Researchers must contact the IRB office via email (NASA-IRB@nasa.gov) to report any information or human subjects issues learned after study closure.

7. The NASA IRB has a process to administratively close studies that have lapsed. In limited circumstances, the IRB chair or designee may allow research activities to temporarily continue pending reinstatement of study approval (e.g., research activities that directly benefit the participant or if abrupt termination of activities would cause harm).

Procedures

1. Prior to the expiration of NASA IRB approval, the NASA IRB Office ensures:
    a. The initial NASA IRB approval letter and the continuing review IRB approval letter reminds researchers of the need for a continuing review application prior to the expiration date.
    b. An automated reminder notification is sent to the PI, PI Proxy, if applicable, and Primary Contact via email 90, 60, and 30 days prior to the study expiration date.
    c. The IRB staff sends an email and a comment through the eIRB informing the PI that the research protocol has (or will) lapse.
2. The PI is responsible for:
    a. Submitting a modification and continuing review (MODCR) or continuing review (CR) with sufficient time to secure IRB approval prior to protocol expiration.
    b. Following study closure procedures to close the study prior to expiration.
3. Study Closure Procedures:
    a. The PI opens a continuing review (CR) submission in the eIRB to initiate study closure.
    b. All of the following boxes in the Research Milestones section (#4) must be checked:
        i. Study is permanently closed to enrollment OR was never open for enrollment
        ii. All subjects have completed all study-related interventions OR not applicable (e.g. study did not include interventions, no subjects were enrolled)
        iii. Collection of identifiable private information is complete OR not applicable (no subjects were enrolled)
        iv. Analysis of identifiable private information is complete OR not applicable (no subjects were enrolled).
4. The NASA IRB:
    a. Reviews all study closures and requests additional information from the PI, if needed, to ensure that conditions for study closure are met.
    b. Notifies the PI when a protocol has lapsed with:
        i. a reminder of the continuing review requirement,
        ii. a reminder that all human subjects research activities must cease, including analysis of identifiable data and,
        iii. a reminder that the study may be administratively closed if the protocol is not renewed within 14 days.
    c. The NASA IRB may elect to administratively close a study if:
        i. No actions have been taken to successfully renew the protocol within 14 days of expiration
        ii. The convened NASA IRB has terminated approval and has provided a statement of the reasons for the IRB's actions to the PI.

1. Termination of IRB approval is reportable to the appropriate federal department or agency head(s) and institutional official(s).

iii. The protocol has lapsed during the review of a continuing review application and the investigator has not responded to the IRB's requests for revisions and/or clarifications within a reasonable timeframe, usually 30 days.

5. In the event NASA IRB approval lapses, the PI must:
    a. Cease all research activity
    b. Secure NASA IRB approval before continuing research activities
    c. Submit a statement explaining the lapse to the NASA IRB with the renewal submission.
6. In cases where the PI believes that enrolled subjects are at risk of harm from stopping the research procedures, the PI must submit the following to the NASA IRB Office:
    a. The number of subjects who may be harmed
    b. A rationale for continuing research, identifying the research procedures that must continue to ensure subject safety, and
    c. A timeline for submission of continuing review
7. The NASA IRB Chair or designee(s) will determine whether temporary continuation is warranted pending reinstatement of study approval.

References

NASA

1. 14 CFR1230.108(a)(4)
2. 14 CFR1230.109(e)
3. 14 CFR1230.115

Version #	Version Notes:	Originated By:	Approved By:	Date Approved:
v.2.1	Formatting and other minor updates	J. Green	M. Covington	18Aug2025
v.2	Removed requirement for separate closure form within eIRB submission	J. Green/J. Ensley Gorshe/A. Garza	M. Covington	19May2022
v.1	Original	F. Llanas/J. Kisenwether	M. Covington	19Oct2020